

The Fable of the Equestrian Ewe and the Shorn Stallion

—“So, children, today *h-I h-am* going to tell you *h-a* story that happened *h-in h-a far h-and* distant land.”

—“Varaz, are you okay? You sound so weird?”

—“Hmm, yeah, you can tell? Well, the doctor says *h-I have h-a laryngeal h-infection—h-Initial Vowel Syndrome*, he called *h-it*. But not to worry, *h-it’s* not contagious. Hopefully *h-it* gets better when *h-I talk h-a* little more. *H-about* this distant land *h-in* which there lived two brothers, Pasupat and Aspapat.”

—“Who are they, Varaz? They live in the land of the Princess and the Knight, right?”

—“What makes you think that, Borān?”

Whenever Varaz starts his story like that, it’s always about the Princess and the Knight.

—“Because that’s how you always tell it, Varaz.”

Her sister now chimes in.

—“It’s about them, right?”

—“Well, *h-Āzar*, you’ll have to wait for the story to *h-unfold*.”

See, when Varaz says it that way, it’s going to be about their favorite! She nods reassuringly to her sister.

—“So, *h-as h-I* was trying to say:”

There in the land called *H-owis H-ekwoskwe*, there lived the two brothers Pasupat and Aspapat. And when they came of age, their father told them:

~“It is time for you guys to earn your keep.”

~“Of course father, we want to contribute, so that you and mother can take it a little easier. We actually discussed it,” Pasupat says, “I wanna be a stable master and Aspapat, he wants to be a shepherd.”

~“What? That’s all wrong. You cannot contradict your own destiny, sons. No, Pasupat, you will shepherd the sheep, and you, Aspapat, you will stable the horses. As it was decreed at your birth.” So, with a heavy heart, the two brothers set out to do their assigned job. But Pasupat, although he tries

his best, he is no herder of sheep: he keeps forgetting the little lambs, and when he tries to shave the sheep, he gets their wool all entangled and it looks like a complete mess, and they all blaa-blaa at him, for they are hungry and he doesn't know where the meadows are. It's a real sheep-wreck!

But it's not that his brother is doing much better: instead of grooming the horses, he ends up shearing them, and they don't like that, and each time he tries to climb on a horse from one side, he falls off from the other side, and the horses are all whinnying and whining for he cannot find their fodder. So, in despair, the two brothers, they decide to go to their mother, to plead with her to change their father's mind. ~"Mother, you have to convince father that he assigned us the wrong tasks."

~"But, Pasupat, does your name not mean Master of Livestock?"

~"I guess so."

~"Therefore, a shepherd your father made you. And you, Aspapat, does your name not mean Master of Horses?," the second brother cannot deny that that is what his name means, "and so, you must tend to the horses!"

~"But mother..."

~"Shh, I am too busy. I have to boil these eggs. Don't bother me anymore." But their mother, children, I don't think she knows how to boil eggs, for she keeps blowing on them, and of course, that's not how it works. So, when their father walks in, he scorns his wife.

~"You don't even know how to boil water! Wife, what are you worth?"

~"Well, you don't even know how to take out the trash! Husband, what worth then are you?" And their parents start quibbling and quibbling, so the two brothers go back to their room.

~"Aspapat, what are we going to do? Our parents don't want to help us?"

~"Well, Pasupat, perhaps we can help each other. See, I can tell you how to keep track of all the sheep. It's quite simple, really, you just count them... but just don't do it when you

lie down.”

~“Oh, why didn’t I think of that? And you shouldn’t worry either, dear Aspapat. Just look the horses in their eyes, and they will do whatever you want...but, brother, never look them in the mouth!” And so Pasupat goes back to the herd and he ponders

~“Didn’t my brother not say, . . . lie down and start counting the sheep?” And so, he does. But *āy wāy*, children, you know what happens then? 🐾

—“What Varaz?”

—“Well, *h*-if you lie down *h*-and start counting sheep, you fall *h*-asleep.”

—“Really?”

—“Yes, *h*-a sheep for *h*-a sleep, ha, ha.”

And when shepherds sleep, sheep sneak out. Well, at least, there is this one curious ewe. She decides:

~“I wanna see a little more of the world. Like, what’s in those stables over there?” Meanwhile, Aspapat, he says to himself.

~“What again did my brother say: look the horses in their mouth? I can do that.” But, children, that was not very wise. 🐾

—“Why Varaz?”

—“When you look *h*-a horse *h*-in the mouth, you gift *h*-it *h*-its freedom. Hmm, *h*-I might have contraposed that wrong—*h*-I *h*-am *h*-only *h*-a Latin, so don’t be too judgmental,¹ but *h*-anyway:”

So, when Aspapat looks in the stallion’s mouth, the stallion thinks.

~“How nice, now I am free to go! I want to check out that meadow over there.” And so, the ewe and the stallion, they meet half way. And the ewe says

~“Oh, you are one of those mighty horses, right. Who can carry a man on their back? What a noble destiny. How I envy you!” But the stallion replies

~“You’re the one to be envied. From your wool, they can make the warmest coats. And it’s so soft!” and the stallion

¹St. Jerome, Commentaries, 538.

looks at the shorn ewe, “And also, it must be so liberating not to have all that hair all the time. Like my tail, it’s so itchy. And on my forehead, all those hairs. I can barely see. I want to be shaven like you.”

~“My name is actually Me.”

~“You are Me the ewe?”

~“Yep, that’s me, ha, ha. And you are?”

~“Stalllion.”

~“Yeah, I knew that.”

~“No, no, that’s my name, Stall-Lion.”

~“Oh, what a nice name your parents gave you. Let’s be friends!”

~“Deal. And then we can help each other fulfill our dream.”

~“So, you want to be shaven, he? I wouldn’t go to my master Pasupat. He’s not very good at it. Why don’t we go to the barber?”

~“What a splendid idea! I know just where he lives, for I always take Aspapat’s father to him. It’s at the other side of the village.” And so, the shorn ewe and equestrian stallion go to the barber’s house.

~“There, that’s his house.”

~“I hope he’s in.”

~“Say, is it not a paradoxical contradiction if I don’t claim that he is not out while he is in, unless his brothers are, or there’d be nobody in the shop?²” The ewe looks puzzled at her companion.

~“Huh?”

~“I don’t know why I said that, it makes no sense. . . . or does it?” As the stallion is still mulling over what he just came up with, the ewe turns to the barber.

~“*Drōd* [Hello], you are the barber of this village, right?”

~“Yes, I am. I am the one who shaves only those in this village who do not shave themselves.³” 🐘

That makes auntie chuckle. Did they miss a pun?

—“Varaz, that’s what barbers do, right?”

²Lewis Carroll, A Logical Paradox, 20.

³Bertrand Russell, The Philosophy of Logical Atomism.

Amazing that the *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn* has figured it out right away. When his friend Peroz Husrow told him the puzzle, he had to explain it four times before he got it. But Peroz Husrow was not very good at explaining, so, hopefully, he is going to do a better job.

—“Well, Borān, that’s true. But there *h*-is *h*-one thing you should never *h*-ask... *h*-oh, no, no, no, ..., the horse just did...”

—“What, Varaz? What?”

THE stallion is curious
~“And who then shaves you?”

~“Ah, good question. Well obviously, I am very good at shaving, so, undoubtedly, I shave myself,” he proudly exclaims, “That way, I do not have to go to the barber ... although, I am actually the barber... but ... I guess it’s okay, ... I don’t have to shave myself because I already do ... wait, that doesn’t make sense. Okay, let’s try again: so, perhaps, I do not shave myself. Yes, that’s it, I am one of those villagers who doesn’t shave himself, and so..., I go the barber to get shaven...but wait, I am the barber, which means that I am going to shave myself, so..., aha, I do shave myself, ... great, then I don’t have the barber shave me...but, wait, the barber, is that not me...? So, I have..., I shave..., the barber’s... beard ... is mine ... to shave...” The barber’s wife comes running to the shop.

~“Oh, no! What did you guys do? You broke him!”

~“We’re so sorry, we didn’t mean to. Does this happen often?”

~“Well, the doctor says that my husband suffers from Antinomitis Circulatosus. Once, when he was a little boy, he went to the library to make a list of all the books that do not mention themselves...”

~“What a strange thing to think of? When do books ever mention themselves.”

~“Well, it can happen. Take for instance this story, we are talking about it now, right? And since everything that happens has to be written down at some point—what else is the point of a story, right—, written in a book that therefore would mention itself through this conversation.” While

the ewe scratches the hair she no longer has, the stallion exclaims.

~“True. That would be kind of fun. Can I just say *dröd* [hello] to the me in the book, ha, ha.”

~“This is not a laughing matter, stalwart stallion! For that one time, he did not return home in the evening and it took days before they found him curled up in a corner of the library, muttering to himself about his list not been listed or something listless like that,” she looks at her husband, “just like this. Antinomitosis Circulatososis, I guess.”

~“So, how did they cure him then?”

~“How would I know. I am no doctor!”

~“Well, we can get him!”

~“Oh, that would be so nice. And perhaps then I can take over from my husband. The customer always comes first, my husband would say. So, dear ewe, a new hue for you, ha, ha. Or just a light shave...”

~“No, no. It’s not for me we came, but for my friend the stallion. His tail bothers him—just cut it, please.”

~“And also those hairs on my head always falling in my eyes.”

~“You’re the customer!”

~“And I will get the doctor,” the ewe is so excited that she is going to carry a man on her back. But she is still a little worried, “Are you going to be alright, Lady barberess?”

~“Oh, don’t worry about me. I don’t need to shave myself, so no danger there...” But, unfortunately, things don’t go really as planned. When the ewe has found the doctor and tells him to sit on her back... well, the doctor, he likes his sweets and he is quite—let’s say—rotund. And so, way too heavy for the poor ewe, who snaps her back under his weight. So, now, the doctor has to carry the poor ewe to the barber’s house.

When they get back at the barbershop, the stallion wants to show off his new cut to his comrade, so he parades around. But why is he wobbling so much? And then there are flies all over him and he cannot swat them away. For his tail has been docked. Who would have known that a horse need his

tail? Well, in this tale, he will have to do without. And the doctor, he doesn't know what to do either with the mumbling barber. So, instead, he looks at the stallion, and says ~"You know, you're quite a cute colt," the stallion looks a little offended by this emasculating comment, "I could make you some brand new horseshoes. I am very good at it!"

~"But aren't you a doctor?"

~"Yeah, well, you know parents, they always want their sons to become doctors..." The ewe, she needs a doctor too, for her broken back, so she thinks, why not try this:

~"Dear doctor, you wouldn't happen to have a brother... who is a blacksmith, do you?"

~"Oh, how did you guess? Yeah, I do."

~"Perhaps we can get him?"

~"Sure, but I am telling you, I can make the best horseshoes in the village!"

~"Just humor me, dear doctor, and go fetch your brother." See children, the ewe has a hunch. Perhaps the brother, he is a better doctor? And so when the two brothers return, the blacksmith exclaims.

~"So, who is it that wants some shorehoes, I mean worsehues, ..., what are does things called again...?" Yeah, not the best blacksmith in town, the ewe thinks. But her inkling was right: he's a much better doctor, treating her back with a bit of chiropractical magic, and getting the barber unstuck with some chiromagical logic.

And so, after all is fixed, our adventurous duo thank the barber and his wife and the two brothers, and they continue on their way to...

~"What is what that big yellow thing in the sky!?"

~"What? You mean the sun?"

~"Yeah, it's so bright." Oh no, the ewe realizes that without his hair, the sunlight is too bright for her companion.

~"Okay, we're going to have to get you a hat." And so, they go look for the hat maker of the village. As luck has it, they bump into the mayor of the village, whom they greet jovially.

~"*Drōd* [Hello], I am Me the ewe."

~"You are not me!?"

~“Oh, no, you have me confused with my sister, Notme.”

~“What a strange name to have?”

~“Yeah, not the best choice our parents made. Each time our master Pasupat forgot her name, he had to ask her, and then she had to say ‘I am Notme.’ And in the end, it got to here.”

~“Yeah, self-deprecation can do that. Like my name, it’s a nightmare.”

~“Your name is Nightmare?”

~“No, no, it is just Knight. But each time I want to introduce myself, as ‘Knight, mayor of this village,’ everyone runs away screaming. Well, I am glad you guys didn’t.”

~“Well, my mother was born during the day, so...” The others don’t get what the horse is trying to say, so the ewe quickly exclaims:

~“Major mayor, we wanna find the hat maker!”

~“Hmm, *abaxshāyid* [sorry], whom did you say you’re looking for? Did you mean the cat shaker. Or is the rat quaker you want? Oh, I see, it’s the the fat baker, right? You know, we also have a mad breaker, but I wouldn’t recommend him. Then better go to the bat taker..., for he’s a good giver...” Luckily, his wife comes running to their rescue and points them to the hat maker’s workshop, who invites them in cordially.

~“So glad that you guys came. I don’t have that many customers, so it will be a pleasure to assist you with your covering needs.” The ewe is a little suspicious. All the villagers are wearing nice hats. So, where are they getting them from? But the stallion just wants that bright light out of his eyes. So, the hat maker gets to work in the back of the shop. And after a while, he returns

~“I got inspired, and instead of one, I made four little hats. Look!” Yeah, children, not what the doctor ordered. They are way too small, and..., in fact...

~“Hey, they look a little like shoes,” the ewe says, “perhaps they fit me?” And sure enough, with a little shoe on each of her paws, she looks so cute! And she thinks she just knows how to get a hat for her friend.

~“Dear hat maker, your brother, he is a cobbler, right? He

can make a really big shoe for us?"

~"How did ewe know, dear you," oops, I meant, "How did you know, dear ewe? My brother has indeed the distinguished privilege of being a cobbler. Come, I'll take you to his atelier." And when they get there, they tell the brother that they want him to make one big, leather shoe—knowing that inevitably:

~"Oops, dear customer, I seem to have forgotten the toes..." The ewe and the stallion look at each other, trying not to laugh, and the stallion replies

~"Well, no worries, I'll just put it on my head then, ha, ha." And the two leave the surprised brothers behind. On their way to ... yeah, where are they going to go next?

~"Oh, I have a cousin we can visit," the ewe says, "he lives all the way in Gurgān."

~"I always wanted to visit that country. They say it's lovely there. Me'll like it there."

~"And ewe too, ha, ha." They joke around.

~"So, who is your cousin?"

~"Gurg."

~"What! He is a *gurg* [wolf]?"

~"Well, he lives in Gurgān, but he is no wolf. Gurg is just his name," she looks down bashfully, "And also, he wears wolf's clothing?"

~"A sheep in wolf's clothing!? Why would he do that?"

~"Well, when he was a little lamb, one day, he was grazing in the pen, when someone called him from the other side of the fence. It was a big, big ram, and it told my cousin that it accidentally had left the fold, and it asked to open the gate, so that it could return to the flock. And so, my cousin let the ram in, but it turned out that the ram was actually a wolf in sheep's clothing, and it ate all my cousin's siblings. So, that's when my cousin decided to wear a wolf's fur, so that way, when wolves would attack again, they wouldn't eat him."

~"Oh, that's quite clever of him."

~"Yeah, although, it doesn't make him very beloved among his own kind. They don't trust him. It's true what they say: a smart sheep is honored everywhere except by his relatives

and his own family.⁴ But I don't mind. I am a free spirit." And as she says that, she darts around in her new shoes, through the meadow glowing in the afternoon sun. But, what is that sound? 🐾

—"What, Varaz, what is it?"

—"We have to go *h*-a little closer to hear. *H*-I think *h*-it's ..."

THe ewe points at a patch of green sprigs singing a song, or is it a ... curse.

~"What are they saying?"

~"Listen! I think they are saying. 'Asp ast [it's a horse]! Asp ast [it's a horse]!"

~"Oh, no, those guys again!" The ewe looks surprised at the stallion.

~"You know them?"

~"Yeah, they are *aspast* [alfalfa], fodder for horses. They are way to fresh to my taste, and very annoying. As if I don't know I am a horse! No, look, at those waving weeds of green grass. That's looks yummy. And they are at least quiet."

~"Well, you can have those, always with the waving and the weaving. I'll try those little sprightly sprigly sprouts." But that turned out to be not such a wise choice, for the ewe cannot digest *aspast* [alfalfa], and the stallion does not stomach grass. So, they have to lie down until ... well, let's say, until the indigestibles have been disposed.

~"Yeah, we probably should stick to our own food."

~"If only it would stop talking! But, come let's go find your cousin. Look, there is the gate to Gurgān." And when they walk through it, they are greeted by a little bird.

~"Oh, look, a wee little birdie." But the bird doesn't like to be called small.

~"Hey, just because you're a huge stallion doesn't mean I am little. But let me introduce myself. I am Epops the hoopoe." While the stallion is a little surprised that the bird can speak, the ewe is in awe.

~"Oh, wow, you're Epops? Really? OMG!" That baffles the stallion even more.

⁴Mark 6:4 (paraphrased).

~“You have heard of this li... this bird?”

~“Yeah, from the Epopee of Epops the Hoopoe. OMG! You’re so famous, esteemed Epops. You accomplished what no one else could. You’re epic!” When the stallion wants to know, what exactly Epops had achieved, the ewe explains.

~“Well, there was a time when the birds were all lost. The nightingale had turned nothingale, the sparrow was full of sorrow, the dove fell out of love, the finch shrunk to a mere inch, and the poor pheasant, well, he was not very pleasant. So, they went to Epops the Hoopoe for help, and he told them that they needed to find the *Senmurw* [Simurg]. With her magical power, she would heal all. But no one knew where she was.”

~“She?”

~“Well, yeah, you didn’t know that the *Senmurw* is a she, the Queen of all birds? Anyway,

*It was in Chin, late one moonless night,
The Senmurw first appeared to mortal sight.⁵*

So, Epops took them all to Chin [China]. It was a long and arduous journey and many birds lost their way. But they finally found her, and all was saved!”

~“How do you know all that?”

~“Oh, King Solomon had decreed one day ‘O sheep! You have been taught the language of birds, and been given everything you need. This is indeed a great privilege.’⁶”

~“Really?”

~“Yeah, and then he added that the Lord is the good shepherd, the good shepherd who lays down his life for the sheep.⁷ So, I guess, that’s why He gave us the Speech of the Birds. And every little lamb, before going to sleep, is told the Epopee of Epops the Hoopoe. And that’s him, right here,” the ewe is jumping up and down from excitement, “isn’t that epic?!”

⁵Attar, Conference of the birds.

⁶Quran, 27:16.

⁷John, 10:11.

The stallion is a little more skeptical.

~“You found the *Senmurw*?”

~“Well, with the aid of my thirty feathered friends.”

~“I am curious, the *Senmurw*, what does she look like?”

~“Like the sun of majesty sending forth its rays, and in the reflection of our faces from the outer world, we contemplated the face of the *Senmurw* of the inner world.⁸” The stallion is not convinced: it sounds more like Epops didn’t see the great bird after all.

~“I guess self-reflection is not a bad sight.”

~“As great as it is an in-sight! But, where are my manners? Welcome to the Valley of Wonderment! Allow me to be your guide. Whom do I have the pleasure to be guiding?”

~“This is Me the ewe.”

~“Well, you are not me!”

~“No, he is Stallion the stallion.” The hoopoe shrugs his shoulders—you can hear him think ‘those foreigners with their weird names’—but he is also glad they came.

~“How fortuitous that I ran into you, for I kind of need your assistance. It just happened and nobody yet knows how the fate of humanity may be at risk! But it’s an unorthodox un-ornithological mare’s nest. So, you valiant stallion, may perhaps be of help.”

~“Sure. We horses have pledged a hippocratic oath to help those in need,” he looks a little sheepish at his friend, “but only horses and humans, though.” Like all sheeple, she shyly shrugs her shorn shoulders.

~“Well, it does involve a human,” the hoopoe explains, and turning to the ewe, “and also your cousin.”

~“Oh no, my cousin. What did he do now?”

~“Well, his disguise might very well be his demise. Come, hurry!” And the Hoopoe starts hopping in front of them.

~“Uhm, dear Epops, is it not easier,” and also much faster, the stallion thinks to himself, “if you’d fly?”

~“I will honor my name, equine inquirer, by hopping to that hole over there.” He points to a big pit in the middle of the

⁸Attar, §45.

meadow. To announce their arrival, the bird lets out his call
 ~“Hu-!” And from the pit, they can hear its reply.
 ~“-mata!”
 ~“Hu-!” the bird goes again, and the echo replies
 ~“-uχta!”
 ~“Hu-!”
 ~“-warshta!” When they reach the rim and look down, they
 can see a she-wolf holding a little baby.
 ~“Hu-!” The baby is pointing to himself.
 ~“-man!”
 ~“Cousin Gurg, what happened?”
 ~“Oh, is that you, cousin ewe?” And doing her name honor,
 she replies.
 ~“Yep, it’s me!”
 ~“Why, it was just the other day you were a little lamb. How
 fast they grow. But yeah, I am a bit in a pickle—ooh, what I
 would not give for a pickle right now—haven’t eaten in three
 days. Well, there I was, a sheep in wolf’s clothing just mind-
 ing his business, when one of my wicked lycan brethren,” he
 sees the puzzled face of his cousin, so he explains, “a wolf,
 I am talking about a real wolf. He was a real glutton, and
 so he one day, he ate the villagers’ donkey—and also a mut-
 ton. Anyway, the villagers were not too happy and they ex-
 claimed,

*If God lets this wolf hunt far and wide,
 if He puts him here to roam about,
 should He then not compensate us without a doubt.*⁹

And so, they, thinking I was the culprit, threw me in this
 pit.”
 ~“Wow, cousin, this is some deep pit. Who dug it?”
 ~“Oh, there used to be a beautiful cypress here, tall as the
 sky. But the King was envious of its majesty, and commanded
 it would be dug out—its root had grown so deep, thus cre-
 ating this huge hole I now find myself trapped in. And his

⁹ Attar, Conference of the Birds, 2790.

men were ordered to bring the tree to his palace. So the carpenters sawed it in pieces for transport and it took a train of 1,300 golden camels to bring it all to his court. But an impious act of such immensitude can not pass with impunity.

*The cypress moves onward,
but fate too is advancing.
And as the tree was felled,
so the king fell by sword.¹⁰*

And thus the splendor of Paradise was hidden from royal hubris, for he conducted himself, that wicked king, by means of the power of the evil planetary influence.¹¹

But that was long ago and long forgotten, and now the villagers thought: a pit is a pit and the deeper the better, so they just threw me in here and no matter how much I bleated with them to have mercy on me, that I was just a sheep in disguise, they left me here to die. But then a few days ago, the King—the son of the old one—, had his men throw this little child in this pit with me. And the King shouted at me ‘Wolf, eat this god-fearing child, so that God may die with him. We have no need for a prophet, we’re doing just fine by ourselves!’”

~“Prophet? The boy is one?” The ewe asks puzzled, for she recalls an old saying

*Beware of false prophets,
which come to you in sheep’s clothing,
but inwardly they are ravenous wolves.¹²*

But then, is this not the opposite, she thinks. And the hoopoe confirms:

~“It is said that he shall tell you even what lies hidden in your nature; he shall be able to tell you whatever you ask

¹⁰Ali ibn Jahm as-Sami.

¹¹Denkard, 3.192.

¹²Matthew, 7:15.

him and he shall perform such things which others cannot perform.¹³ So, we need you, valiant stallion, for the King's name, it's Unbridled Horse, and that's why I thought of you. That Unbridled Horse of a king, that jealous zealot, doesn't want to hear the message of good and evil! *Āy wāy!* And without this message of hope a hoopoe is just a heap of hapless . . .," Epops shakes his head and let's out a sorrowful, "Hu-!" and the little baby answers

~"-ngry!" The little boy is bawling now, making the ewe's cousin look up to them in despair.

~"See, the infant thinks I am a she-wolf—perhaps not the smartest idea of me to put on a she-wolf's dress, but the fur is so much softer—anyway, I cannot feed it. A ram I am, so you my ewe. . ."

~"Let me do it then! I mean me me, not ewe me. True to my hippocratic oath, I will feed the baby!," the stallion interrupts, and then turns to his ovid friend, "And you should go fetch his mother, the milkmaid." But before he can jump in, the ewe stops him.

~"Dear whinnying wayfarer, a mare you are not and not a mount I am. Perhaps we should stop horsing around and swap duties. Let me suckle the little boy and you fetch his mother. In spite of our aspirations, we should stick to our qualifications."

~"Well-spoken, my bleating companion. Let's save humanity!"

~"And theology! Oh, and bring a rope. Then you can pull them out of their pitiful pituation."

~"And to fasten the rope, you can juggle with your knuckle the buckle while you suckle . . ." *Āy wāy*, children, something is affecting our two friends. Something else is happening, an omen of amazing amend! 🐐

—"What is happening, Varaz."

—"Perquisite *h*-of persistent patience."

—"Huh?"

—"Well, we're you, children, not hoping for this. . ."

¹³Namah Shat Vakhshur Zartust, 50–54.

And there arrive on the scene, the perennial heroes, the saviors of the day—and also of the night—the redeemers of gods and humans alike, the good-thinkers, the better-speakers and the best-actors...

~“We heard of a great evil that happened in Gurgān, and we came as fast we could. Me, the Princess...”

~“And I the knight!” 🐾

Yay! A story of their favorites after all. Although, the ewe and the stallion were cool too.

—“They’re going to help, right, Varaz?”

—“H-of course.”

With a little magic and a lot of pulling and shoving, the infelicitous infant is rescued from the inferno of infidelity. And turning to his mother, he speaks

*Wail not, my mother dear, for not from these
Shall harm approach me or destruction seize.
God is my guardian and my protection.*¹⁴

Living up to her name, his mother now finally can feed her most righteous son with the nectar of wisdom. And thus, the message of the little boy will spread to all four corners of the world: think well, speak better, and, most importantly, do your best!

~“Huzzah,” the ewe chants, “huzzah for the Princess and the Knight!” Our two animal protagonists are really in awe of these new arrivals.

~“Wow. That princess is something,” the stallion thinks, “how pretty she is!” He kind of envies the Knight and he wishes he was him. And the ewe, she cannot keep her eyes off the handsome countenance of the Knight. What a lucky gall that princess is! She wishes it was her! 🐾

—“But, children, there can be no story without *h*-a lesson *h*-and we have come to *h*-it!”

—“What is it, Varaz?”

¹⁴Zartusht Nameh.

Meanwhile, the Knight has been eying the stallion and he now thinks

~“*Pargast* [Damn], a sturdy horse! That would make my life a lot easier, always having to run behind the princess. For with her little legs, phew, she can run fast.” And so he bridles the stallion and mounts it. And the princess notices the ewe and thinks

~“Hmm, winter is coming. I need a warm coat if we’re going to fight the demons in the north. What a nice woolen fleece she has.” And she shears the ewe and spins herself a comfy coat. And when they walk away in the sunset, the Knight riding on her former friend, the ewe starts sobbing.

~“Is it then true, Epops, that we cannot change who we are? Is our fate predetermined? Am I only but me?”

~“Perhaps you shouldn’t ask who you are but for whom!”

~“Huh?”

~“Will you serve the Lord of Goodness, or will you be a servant to the Master of Evil? Will you seek the Righteous Order or will you pursue the Malevolent Lie? Whatever has been given to you at birth, you still have to decide in which direction you’ll take it,” the little boy was sucking his thumb, but he now takes it out of his mouth and points it upwards. I think he agrees, children. The hoopoe though feels sorry for the poor ewe, so he adds, “but while you’re not built to carry a man, perhaps a boy you can?” Having heard that, with the little boy on her shaven back, happily, the ewe seeks refuge in the acres of space that lie between her and her destiny. 🐘

—“Varaz, did you not say that the ewe was already shaven when she escaped. And besides, no knight is ever going to mount a horse without a tail.”

—“Very *h*-astutely *h*-observed, Shirowe. But to thank his rescuers, the boy performed his first miracle by giving the *h*-ewe back her woolen fleece *h*-and the stallion his whipping tail. For what was well-thought *h*-out by God should remain well-executed by man. And *h*-I think, that was well-said by me, ha, ha.”